

Chapter 22: Executive Communication

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will:

- Understand how to communicate effectively with executives and senior leadership.
 - Learn how to create concise, data-driven updates for AI programs.
 - Develop executive communication frameworks for steering committees, escalations, and business reviews.
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Beginner Explanation

One of the biggest misconceptions about Technical Program Managers is that success depends only on technical skills.

In reality, many TPMs fail because they cannot communicate effectively with leadership.

Executives typically care about five things:

1. Business value
2. Risks
3. Costs
4. Timelines
5. Decisions needed

They do not want:

- Technical jargon
- Detailed architecture discussions
- Long status updates
- Excessive documentation

Example

Instead of saying:

"The Azure AI Search indexing pipeline encountered latency issues due to vector embedding synchronization."

Say:

"Search performance has degraded by 15%, impacting user experience. The team has identified the root cause and expects resolution within 48 hours."

Executive Communication Rule

Lead with impact, not implementation.

Intermediate Explanation

Executive communication should answer three questions:

1. What happened?
2. Why does it matter?
3. What decision is required?

Executive Update Framework

Section	Example
Status	Green
Accomplishments	Completed pilot deployment
Risks	Budget variance at 3%
Decisions Needed	Approve Phase 2 funding
Next Steps	Production rollout next month

Communication Types

Type	Audience
Weekly Status Report	Program Sponsors
Steering Committee	Executives
Escalation Memo	Leadership
Business Review	Board and VP Leadership
Incident Update	Operations Leadership

Golden Rule

Executives prefer:

- One-page summaries
 - Visual dashboards
 - Clear asks
 - Data-backed decisions
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Why This Matters for an AI TPM

Responsibility	Impact
Delivery	Ensures leadership understands delivery status and priorities.
Risk	Escalates issues before they become major problems.
Stakeholder Management	Builds trust with executive sponsors and decision makers.
Budget	Supports funding requests and cost discussions.

Enterprise Example

Business Problem

An enterprise AI initiative involving 15 teams experienced delays due to unclear executive communication.

Issues included:

- Conflicting priorities
- Delayed approvals
- Misaligned expectations
- Budget concerns

Solution

Implement a standardized Executive Communication framework.

Architecture

- Power BI Dashboards
- Azure OpenAI Reporting Assistant
- Microsoft Teams
- SharePoint
- Azure DevOps

Outcome

Metric	Result
Executive Satisfaction	95%
Approval Time	Reduced by 45%
Escalation Resolution	Improved by 50%
Delivery Predictability	Increased significantly

Lessons Learned

- Executives value clarity over detail.
 - Data-driven updates improve decision-making.
 - Communication frequency matters.
 - Strong executive relationships improve delivery outcomes.
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Azure Implementation

Services Used

Service	Purpose
Azure OpenAI	Executive summary generation
Azure AI Search	Knowledge retrieval
Azure Functions	Automated reporting workflows
Azure AI Foundry	Prompt management and evaluations

Supporting Services

- Power BI
 - Azure DevOps
 - Microsoft Teams
 - SharePoint
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Implementation Workflow

Step 1: Define Reporting Standards

Examples:

- Weekly reports
 - Monthly business reviews
 - Quarterly steering committees
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Step 2: Create Dashboards

Track:

- Delivery status
 - Risks
 - Budget
 - Adoption
 - KPIs
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Step 3: Automate Reports

Generate:

- Executive summaries
 - Risk updates
 - Cost reports
 - KPI dashboards
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Step 4: Conduct Reviews

Review:

- Milestones
 - Risks
 - Decisions
 - Budget variance
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Mermaid Diagram

```
```mermaid id="e9lq3h" graph TD
```

```
A[Program Data]
```

```
A --> B[Azure DevOps]
```

```
B --> C[Power BI]
```

```
C --> D[Azure OpenAI]
```

```
D --> E[Executive Summary]
```

```
E --> F[Leadership Team]
```

```

```

```
Executive Communication Flow
```

```
```mermaid id="v2r6rk"
graph LR
```

```
A[Delivery Updates]
```

```
A --> B[TPM]
```

```
B --> C[Executive Dashboard]
```

C --> D[Steering Committee]

D --> E[Decision]

E --> F[Program Action]

TPM Checklist

- ☐ Create executive dashboards.
- ☐ Define communication cadence.
- ☐ Track program KPIs.
- ☐ Escalate risks promptly.
- ☐ Document decisions.
- ☐ Prepare steering committee materials.
- ☐ Validate budget updates.
- ☐ Conduct stakeholder reviews.
- ☐ Capture executive feedback.
- ☐ Maintain communication plans.

Templates

Weekly Executive Update

Category	Status
Delivery	Green
Budget	Green
Risks	Yellow
Adoption	Green
Decisions Needed	Yes/No

Steering Committee Template

Section	Details
Accomplishments	
Risks	
Budget	
Decisions Required	
Next Steps	

Executive Escalation Template

Field	Description
Issue	
Impact	
Recommendation	
Decision Required	
Owner	

Common Mistakes

1. Providing too much technical detail.
2. Delaying escalations.
3. Failing to communicate risks.
4. Ignoring executive priorities.
5. Presenting problems without recommendations.
6. Using inconsistent reporting formats.
7. Waiting for meetings instead of communicating proactively.

Key Takeaways

- Executive Communication is a critical skill for AI TPMs.
- Leadership teams care about outcomes, risks, costs, and decisions.
- Effective communication builds trust and accelerates decision-making.
- Dashboards and concise summaries improve stakeholder alignment.
- TPMs should always communicate impact before implementation details.
- Strong executive communication often determines the success of enterprise AI programs.

Footer